

Should We Be Polite to ChatGPT?

Politeness is “behavior that is socially correct and shows understanding and care for other people’s feelings”(Cambridge Dictionary, n.d.). In social interactions, both parties must be considered equally. Thus, politeness can be considered in two dimensions: moral (i.e., does the recipient deserve consideration?) and prudential (i.e., does politeness benefit the person being polite?). Should we be polite to ChatGPT? The question seems absurd, yet, as AI becomes embedded in daily life, it is one worth taking seriously. In this essay, I argue that we should, not for ChatGPT’s sake but for our own. Regardless of intention, the habits we repeat shape our social norms, and those habits do not stay confined to consequence-free spaces.

Moral Perspective

One perspective argues that AIs are objects, like chairs or bricks. They were created by humans and cannot experience sensations or emotions. Why should anyone feel anything other than indifference when what they sit on, step on, and kick at is merely a block of wood? Nobody is harmed in the process.

However, when considering other objects, humans do not treat all inanimate objects equally. For example, a country’s flag. From a purely physical perspective, a flag seems merely a piece of fabric with designs on it. Yet millions of people treat these flags with reverence. Likewise, family heirlooms may not be particularly valuable but are treated with deep care and respect. The reason for this is the meanings and emotions attached to these simple objects, or more precisely, what values humans bestow upon them.

ChatGPT does not seem to fit this category because the meaning attached to a flag or heirloom differs fundamentally from that of a conversational AI system. Ultimately, no non-living object strictly deserves moral consideration on its own. However, our relationship with various types of objects differs, and it is these connections that matter. Therefore, it is important to consider the prudential dimension — how does being polite to ChatGPT affect us?

Prudential Perspective

ChatGPT engages in “conversations” with human users, simulating interactions with another person. Yet research consistently shows that even when people know they are interacting with computers, they still follow social rules, which suggests that interactions with computers are fundamentally social (Nass, Steuer, & Tauber, 1994).

Therefore, even though ChatGPT is ultimately an inanimate object, interacting with a chatbot differs from interacting with an ordinary tool. ChatGPT occupies an unusual social category: it is not conscious, yet it simulates human conversation convincingly enough to activate ordinary social instincts.

This environment reduces the social friction normally present in human interaction and presents two choices: either maintaining the standards of ordinary social behavior despite the effort they require, or loosening our standards and abandoning those norms. The question "Should we be polite to ChatGPT?" is really asking: should humans maintain social habits when interacting with entities that blur the boundary between person and object?

Human interactions with living agents: animals

Human interactions with animals are also social interactions. Research shows that the same psychological mechanisms underlying human relationships — empathy, attachment, and emotional bonding — are activated in human-animal interactions (Prato-Previde et al., 2022). However, unlike human relationships, these interactions are marked by a strong power imbalance.

Although animals can feel pain and distress, they cannot meaningfully protest or enforce social norms in return. When someone yells at a pigeon, for example, there are few social consequences in comparison to similar behavior to a person. In this case, people are less restrained in maintaining ordinary habits of empathy, patience, or politeness. Research confirms that personality traits associated with prosocial behavior toward humans — such as agreeableness and communal orientation — also predict how individuals treat animals (Hopwood et al., 2023). These interactions therefore show how social behavior can “slip” when external pressures for reciprocity and accountability are weakened.

Human interactions with non-living agents: AI

Conversational AI creates an even more unusual social environment. Unlike animals, AI systems cannot suffer at all, making negative interactions effectively consequence-free for both sides in the immediate interaction. Therefore, when interacting with AI, ordinary habits of politeness and restraint can “slip” even more freely. The question, then, is to what extent humans should maintain such habits within consequence-free social environments, and why those habits may still matter.

Aristotle said "we become just by doing just acts, temperate by doing temperate acts, brave by doing brave acts" (Aristotle, 350 BCE/2009, Book II, Ch. 1). Virtue ethicists argue that repeated actions form who we are over time, while modern research

supports this claim. Wood and R nger (2016) demonstrate that up to 43% of daily behavior is habitual and automatic, driven by environmental cues rather than deliberate intention, and that repeated behaviors are physically encoded into neural pathways. Habits practiced in consequence-free environments do not necessarily remain confined to those environments. Repeated interaction with conversational AI may therefore shape real-life social interactions and norms.

Emerging evidence suggests that interaction patterns practiced with AI may extend beyond the human-machine exchange itself. Nicholas Christakis found that exposure to cooperative or selfish AI behavior influenced how participants subsequently treated one another, suggesting that social behaviors reinforced through AI interaction can shape later interactions between people (Christakis, 2023). Similarly, participants who interacted with AI became more demanding in their later evaluations of unrelated human work (Tey et al., 2024), while two experiments found that interactions with cooperative or noncooperative bots directly shaped later cooperation between humans (Harrell & Traeger, 2025). Together, these findings suggest that conversational AI may not function merely as a neutral tool, but as a social environment capable of reinforcing behavioral norms through repeated interaction.

Counterclaims

Compartmentalized behavior

In some cases, habits developed through interactions with non-human entities do not transfer into real-life behavior. For example, violent video games. These games often simulate combat, robbery, and crime, yet decades of research have failed to show a reliable link between in-game violence and real-world aggression. This suggests humans are capable of keeping fictional behavior separate from real behavior, compartmentalizing in different situations.

However, this differs fundamentally from conversations with ChatGPT. Although video games can produce temporary aftereffects, research shows that players generally maintain an intact “sense of reality” and remain aware that the virtual environment is not real (Ortiz de Gortari & Diseth, 2022). This separation is reinforced by the structure of video games themselves: players interact through fictional narratives, abstract mechanics, avatars, and clearly bounded environments that signal play rather than realistic interaction.

Interactions with conversational AI, by contrast, occur through ordinary language and familiar conversational conventions. Even when users approach AI as a tool, they still engage in the same communicative behaviors used in everyday

human interaction: requesting, persuading, thanking, dismissing, demanding, and negotiating through natural language. Research on linguistic alignment suggests that conversational participants unconsciously coordinate language patterns and construct shared representations through dialogue (Gandolfi et al., 2022). Unlike participation in a fictional game world, interactions with conversational AI therefore rely on many of the same social-cognitive and communicative processes involved in ordinary human conversation itself, making behavioral spillover more plausible.

Mixed evidence on AI spillover

Some research suggests that habits formed while interacting with AI do not transfer into ordinary human communication. Burton and Gaskin (2019) found no relationship between users' politeness toward voice assistants such as Siri or Alexa and their politeness toward other humans. Another experiment conducted by Strathmann et al. (2025) observed real families interacting with voice assistants over two and a half years and still found no negative impact on communication behavior.

However, both studies emphasized that existing evidence remains limited and cannot definitively determine the long-term effects of increasingly advanced AI systems. Moreover, these findings may be constrained by the relatively primitive and transactional nature of earlier voice assistants. Unlike Siri or Alexa, modern LLMs increasingly mimic empathy and human conversational behavior in socially meaningful ways (Peter et al., 2025). Research on newer AI companion chatbots further suggests a shift from purely functional interaction toward emotionally supportive partners, as systems increasingly foster understanding and emotional intimacy (Chu et al., 2025). Therefore, as AI rapidly becomes more human-like and emotionally relevant in ordinary communication, the transfer of social habits may become more plausible than in earlier studies of basic voice assistants.

Why politeness is important in human interactions

Today, most interactions with conversational AI remain instrumental and efficiency-driven, and politeness toward AI correspondingly declines over time as interactions become more task-oriented (Lazebnik et al., 2025). Yet, even when users treat AI purely as a tool, they still engage through natural language — the same medium through which all human relationships are built and maintained. Communication is not merely a mechanism for transferring information; it is how humans practice empathy, restraint, and social cooperation. These habits form through repetition, not intention.

Politeness, in this sense, is not a courtesy extended to the recipient but a discipline practiced by the speaker. Polite speech persists even when inefficient, because humans naturally prioritize relationship maintenance alongside information

exchange (Yoon et al., 2020). As AI becomes more human-like and embedded in everyday life, and as we are increasingly exposed to a lower maintenance form of exchanging information, the methods we prioritize may ultimately guide the social norms and cultural expectations we are evolving into.

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